



Limited Edition BB Z10

BlackBerry announced recently that it will launch a limited edition, flaming red coloured BlackBerry Z10 smartphone. <http://dgit.in/14OWWch>

Star Wars spin-off movies

Disney announced that they will release spin-off movies based on individual Star Wars characters after the release of "Episode VII"

Smartphones Test

HOW WE TESTED

With manufacturers looking to make their mark in the budget phone segment, we have seen a slew of homogenous devices hit store shelves. This category is dominated by Android with a few Windows Phone powered devices thrown into the mix. Most of the Android devices are quite homogenous, which is to say that they do the same thing, and the difference lies in the aesthetic value such as a different interface or preloaded apps.

The price range for this shootout is any device under ₹20,000. We divided the 25 devices we received for this shootout into two price brackets – up to ₹15,000 and ₹15,001 and above. The street price of the devices was used to place them into the categories and not the MRP's printed on the box. A majority of the devices run on the Android OS and we have four Windows Phone powered devices as a part of the shootout. To

start with, we synched our Google account and performed the software update. Some of them received software update but for most of them it was just an update for the preloaded apps.

After the update, we ran a bunch of benchmarks on all the devices to see how the raw hardware performs. This not only helps us in determining the final best performer but also tells us, which of the two homogenous products boasting of similar hardware were better optimised.

After running the raw performance benchmarks, we tested to see how the smartphone works as a multimedia and smart device. For this we played some MP3 songs and a bunch of videos. We didn't install a third party video player, as we wanted to see what formats would play natively on the smartphones. We also ran a bunch of YouTube videos.

We also downloaded a few apps and games from the Play Store and the Windows Phone Store to see how they would perform. These are apps you use on a daily basis like Facebook, Angry Birds, Temple Run, News apps and more.

We assessed the build quality and comfort of the devices on the basis of the materials used, placement of connectivity options and hardware buttons, among other criterion.

Last, but not least, the ability of the smartphone to make calls. Yes, the smartphones these days may be your multimedia, entertainment and work buddies, but above all things the device needs to be able to make a simple phone call and send a text message. Keeping the SIM constant, we moved around to see how the device would perform under various network conditions and also to judge the quality and signal strength during the calls.

up to ₹20,000. Twenty one of these devices run on Google's Android OS and there are only four devices sporting Microsoft's Windows Phone OS. That just goes to show how popular Google's Android operating system really is on smartphones sold below the 20k mark.

We have further divided the smartphones into two price brackets (sub 15k and between 15k and 20k) to better analyze them against their peers and give readers a better picture of the devices against each other. Let's take a closer look.

SMARTPHONES BELOW ₹15,000

This price bracket can be considered as the testing waters for those that want to invest in their first smartphone. You may not get a powerhouse in terms of the specifications and the display too is fairly basic but what you do get is a good user experience. Most of the devices are homogenous with their capabilities but the skin on the OS is what distinguishes one from the other along with the hardware specification. You also have a variety of screen sizes to

choose from ranging from the tiny 3.2-inch all the way up to 5.9-inches. All the devices show off a rear camera and there are a few that compromise on the front facing one. Out of the box, all the Android devices run on Android 4.0 ICS with the exception of the iBall Andi 4.5q and the Micromax A116 Canvas HD that runs on Android 4.1.1 Jelly Bean straight out of the box.

Design

The Videocon A30 is the cheapest phone on our list but doesn't seem so if you look at

the build of the device. It has the standard candy bar form factor with the four capacitive touch buttons at the bottom and front facing camera at the top. The rear of the phone has a glossy white finish that not only makes it a fingerprint magnet but susceptible to scratches as well.

Place the Karbonn A9+ next to the Videocon A30 and unless you see the branding, you won't be able to tell the devices apart. The location of the front facing camera along with the power button is different on the two devices and that's about it. The

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